DISEC / GA1

DISEC originated from the establishment of the United Nations in 1945 and became one of the General Assembly's principal committees. Its early work focused heavily on the dangers created by atomic energy and nuclear weapons, with the committee recommending the General Assembly's first resolution on 24 January 1946. Over subsequent decades, its agenda expanded to include broader questions of disarmament, arms regulation and international security. Major developments included the establishment of the UN Disarmament Commission in 1952 and three Special Sessions on Disarmament in 1978, 1982 and 1988. Today, DISEC remains the First Committee of the General Assembly and continues to address both traditional and emerging threats to international security.

The Disarmament and International Security Committee (DISEC) is the First Committee of the United Nations General Assembly (GA1), focusing on issues related to international peace, security, disarmament, and the regulation of weapons. DISEC addresses major global security challenges such as nuclear proliferation, conventional weapons, emerging military technologies, arms control, and the prevention of armed conflict. The committee encourages member states to negotiate peaceful solutions, strengthen international cooperation, and develop frameworks that promote global stability while respecting national sovereignty.

Topic 1 -

The Rise of Autonomous Weapon Systems and the Establishment of Strict International Regulations on Their Development and Use.

Topic Agenda

The rapid advancement of artificial intelligence and military technology has led to the development of Autonomous Weapon Systems (AWS), which are capable of identifying, selecting, and engaging targets with varying degrees of human involvement. While these systems may offer potential military advantages, their increasing proliferation raises significant concerns regarding accountability, civilian protection, escalation of conflicts, and compliance with international humanitarian law.The international community remains divided over how autonomous weapons should be developed, deployed, and regulated. Some states support strict human oversight and international limitations, while others argue that emerging technologies can improve military precision and reduce risks to personnel when used responsibly. As autonomous capabilities continue to advance, the absence of universally accepted regulations creates uncertainty surrounding responsibility for decisions made by autonomous system.

This topic encourages delegates to assess the security, ethical, and legal challenges posed by Autonomous Weapon Systems and explore the development of effective international regulations. Delegates should consider measures to ensure meaningful human oversight, accountability, transparency, responsible technological development, and international cooperation, while balancing national security interests with the need to maintain global peace and stability.

Present Issues

The rapid integration of artificial intelligence into military operations has intensified concerns surrounding autonomous weapons and the future of warfare. In 2024, global military expenditure reached approximately $2.7 trillion, an increase of 9.4% in one year and the largest annual increase recorded by SIPRI since at least 1988. At the same time, 49 countries experienced armed conflict in 2024, with approximately 239,000 conflict-related deaths, the highest annual figure recorded for the 2018–2024 period. Military AI is already being incorporated into conflicts, including applications involving targeting, intelligence analysis, planning, and autonomous systems. Despite these developments, the international community has yet to establish comprehensive, legally binding rules specifically governing autonomous weapon systems. International discussions on lethal autonomous weapons have continued for more than a decade, demonstrating the difficulty of reaching agreement on human control, accountability, and legal limitations. The combination of rapidly advancing military technology, increasing global military expenditure, and ongoing armed conflicts highlights the urgency of establishing clear international standards for the responsible development and use of autonomous weapons.

Key Issues Delegates has to address

Establishing Meaningful Human Control
Determining the appropriate level of human involvement required before an autonomous weapon can identify, select, or engage a target.

Accountability and Responsibility
Establishing who should be held responsible when an autonomous weapon causes unlawful harm—the state, military commander, operator, developer, or manufacturer.

International Regulation of AWS
Determining whether autonomous weapons should be banned, strictly regulated, or permitted under specific conditions through an international framework.

Compliance with International Humanitarian Law
Ensuring AWS can comply with principles such as distinction, proportionality, and precaution during armed conflict.

Protection of Civilians
Reducing the risk of civilian casualties and ensuring autonomous systems can reliably distinguish between legitimate military targets and civilians.

Transparency and Verification
Creating mechanisms for states to report their development and deployment of autonomous weapons while preventing the misuse of sensitive military information.

Arms Race and Global Security
Addressing the possibility that rapid development of AWS could create a new international arms race and increase tensions between states.

Development and Testing Standards
Establishing international standards for the testing, reliability, and safety of autonomous weapons before they are deployed.

International Cooperation and Technology Sharing
Encouraging states to cooperate on responsible AI development while preventing advanced military technologies from being transferred to actors that could misuse them.

Preventing Unauthorized or Uncontrolled Use
Developing safeguards to prevent autonomous weapons from being deployed or operating outside authorized military objectives or established rules of engagement.

Guiding Questions

To what extent should the development and use of Autonomous Weapon Systems be permitted?

How can states ensure that Autonomous Weapon Systems remain under meaningful human control throughout their deployment?

What measures can be implemented to ensure that states conduct extensive testing and risk assessments before deploying Autonomous Weapon Systems?

What key factors should be considered to ensure the safety and responsible use of Autonomous Weapon Systems?

How can Autonomous Weapon Systems be responsibly utilized to address critical security challenges and other pressing issues faced by states?

Recommended Sources

SIPRI – Autonomy in Weapon Systems

UNODA – Lethal Autonomous Weapon Systems

ICRC – ICRC Position on Autonomous Weapon Systems

UNODA – CCW Group of Governmental Experts on LAWS

ICRC – What You Need to Know About Autonomous Weapons

Topic 2 -

The Role of Maritime Smuggling Routes in the International Trafficking of Small Arms and Light Weapons

Topic Agenda

The increasing use of maritime routes for the illicit trafficking of Small Arms and Light Weapons (SALW) has become a significant challenge to international peace and security. Criminal networks, armed groups, and other non-state actors exploit international shipping routes, ports, coastal areas, and gaps in maritime border controls to transport firearms across national borders. The global nature of maritime trade, combined with the vast number of commercial vessels and shipping containers moving between countries, creates difficulties for states in detecting and preventing the illegal movement of weapons.The international community remains divided over how maritime firearms trafficking should be addressed while respecting national sovereignty and the legitimate movement of commercial goods. Some states advocate for stronger port inspections, intelligence-sharing, maritime surveillance, container tracking, and international cooperation, while others raise concerns regarding the costs of enhanced security measures, interference with legitimate trade, and the jurisdictional challenges associated with monitoring vessels in international waters. Differences in national capabilities and maritime enforcement systems further complicate efforts to establish consistent international standards.

This topic encourages delegates to examine the role of maritime smuggling routes in facilitating the international trafficking of SALW and assess the effectiveness of existing international mechanisms for preventing their illicit movement. Delegates should consider measures including improved port and customs security, intelligence-sharing between states, vessel and container monitoring, enhanced end-user verification, cooperation between maritime authorities, and stronger mechanisms for tracing and intercepting illicit shipments. At the same time, delegates should examine the safety and security practices of states with high volumes of international trade, particularly whether they are effectively implementing existing regulations and maintaining adequate measures to prevent the illicit trafficking of weapons.

Present Issues

The international trafficking of Small Arms and Light Weapons (SALW) through maritime routes remains a significant challenge to international peace and security, particularly because the enormous volume of legitimate global shipping makes it difficult for authorities to identify illicit weapons shipments. According to the United Nations, more than **850 million civilian-held firearms** existed worldwide in 2017, while only around **12% were registered**, highlighting the broader challenges surrounding firearm tracing and control. Maritime trafficking is further facilitated by vulnerabilities in ports, shipping containers, customs systems, and information-sharing between states, with criminal networks exploiting differences in national regulations and enforcement capabilities. INTERPOL has identified port security and the movement of illicit goods through maritime infrastructure as important areas requiring stronger international cooperation. Regions such as the **Caribbean, Latin America, and parts of Africa** face particular concerns regarding firearms trafficking and its links to organized crime and armed violence. Current international efforts therefore focus on strengthening port and customs security, improving intelligence-sharing, tracing firearms, and increasing cooperation between maritime and law-enforcement authorities. However, significant challenges remain in ensuring that states with high volumes of

international trade are effectively enforcing existing regulations while maintaining secure and efficient trade networks.

Key Issues Delegates has to address

Strengthening Port and Maritime Security
Developing effective security measures at ports, harbors, and maritime borders to detect and prevent the illicit movement of Small Arms and Light Weapons (SALW) without unnecessarily disrupting legitimate international trade.

Container and Cargo Monitoring
Improving the screening and tracking of high-risk cargo and shipping containers while balancing enhanced security with the efficiency of global maritime commerce.

State Responsibility and Enforcement
Determining the responsibility of states with major ports, shipping industries, or firearms exports to ensure that existing international regulations are properly enforced and that their territories are not exploited for weapons trafficking.

International Intelligence Sharing
Establishing stronger mechanisms for states to exchange information on suspected trafficking networks, vessels, shipments, and patterns of illicit firearms movement while protecting sensitive national-security information.

Tracing and Identification of Firearms
Improving international systems for marking, recording, and tracing firearms to determine their origin and identify points where legally produced weapons enter illicit markets.

Combating Organized Criminal Networks
Addressing the role of transnational criminal organizations in facilitating the movement of SALW across maritime borders and strengthening international cooperation to disrupt their networks.

Corruption and Port Security
Addressing corruption, bribery, and weaknesses within customs and port authorities that may allow illicit weapons shipments to pass through maritime infrastructure.

International Legal Frameworks
Assessing the effectiveness of existing international agreements and mechanisms governing the prevention of illicit firearms trafficking and determining where stronger international standards may be required.

National Sovereignty and Freedom of Navigation
Balancing increased maritime inspections and international enforcement mechanisms with states' sovereignty, jurisdiction over their territorial waters, and the principle of freedom of navigation.

Balancing Security with International Trade
Ensuring that stronger measures against weapons trafficking do not unnecessarily delay legitimate shipping, increase trade costs, or place disproportionate burdens on states that depend heavily on maritime commerce.

Regional Cooperation and Maritime Enforcement
Encouraging neighboring states to coordinate customs, coast guard, and law-enforcement efforts, particularly in regions where maritime trafficking contributes to organized crime and regional instability.

Preventing Diversion of Legal Firearms
Strengthening safeguards to prevent legally manufactured and exported firearms from being diverted from their intended recipients and subsequently entering illicit international markets.

Guiding Questions

To what extent should states be held responsible for preventing the use of their maritime infrastructure in the illicit trafficking of Small Arms and Light Weapons?

How can states strengthen port, customs, and maritime security measures while maintaining the efficiency of legitimate international trade?

What measures can be implemented to improve the identification, tracing, and interception of illicit firearms transported through maritime routes?

How can states strengthen international intelligence-sharing and cooperation to identify and disrupt transnational firearms trafficking networks?

What key factors should be considered when regulating maritime shipping and cargo inspections while respecting national sovereignty and freedom of navigation?

How can international organizations and states support countries with limited maritime-security capabilities in preventing the illicit trafficking of Small Arms and Light Weapons?

To what extent should countries with high volumes of international trade be required to demonstrate that their ports and shipping systems comply with international firearms-trafficking regulations?

How can states address corruption and weaknesses in port-security systems that allow illicit weapons shipments to enter international markets?

Recommended Sources

UNODC – Firearms Trafficking

UNODC – Global Report on Trafficking in Persons

INTERPOL – Firearms Trafficking

INTERPOL – Port Security

IMO – Maritime Security

Country List

🇺🇸 United States

🇨🇳 China

🇷🇺 Russia

🇬🇧 United Kingdom

🇫🇷 France

🇮🇳 India

🇯🇵 Japan

🇹🇷 Türkiye

🇩🇪 Germany

🇰🇷 South Korea

🇦🇺 Australia

🇮🇹 Italy

🇧🇷 Brazil

🇪🇬 Egypt

🇦🇪 UAE

🇸🇬 Singapore

🇳🇱 Netherlands

🇨🇦 Canada

🇸🇪 Sweden

🇮🇱 Israel

🇲🇽 Mexico

🇨🇴 Colombia

🇳🇬 Nigeria

🇿🇦 South Africa

🇵🇦 Panama